

Language	Number of books
Java	3
JavaScript	2
PHP	2
C, C#, Perl, Python, Objective-C, C++	1

Java is a topper again with three bestsellers. Though there are differences in numbers, this rating is not altogether different from the other two tables, is it?

So the winner is...

Tiobe announces the 'Language of the year' award every year. Since C# has gained much popularity this year, Tiobe has hinted that there is a good chance it will get the award. Previous winners were C - 2008, Python - 2007, Ruby - 2006, Java - 2005, PHP - 2004, and C++ - 2003.

Though languages like Objective-C, Python, Ruby and JavaScript are popular, they are still not comparable to the biggies like Java and C. C++ and (Visual) Basic continue to lose their share to others. C# is gaining popularity, but one disadvantage is that it is proprietary (though for namesake it complies to the ECMA standard). The real competition seems to be between Java, C and PHP. With the Internet becoming more pervasive, it looks like PHP will only become more popular. But Java and C are certainly more popular than PHP, so we'll have to eliminate PHP. Now the real tie is between Java and C!

Let us compare the strengths and weaknesses of these languages. Java is for application programming whereas C is for systems programming. With the wider use of embedded systems, C can become more popular, but Java is actually gaining popularity in the embedded space. Java has kept growing (both the language and its library) and has adapted faster than C. How about standards? C has, and Java hasn't. But, most C compilers aren't C99 compatible even after a decade of the release of the last standard: C is very slow in adopting new features and adding library features.

Let's see what the future holds for these two languages. C is still popular though very old, which might be because there is no real alternative. Google's Go language might gain C's share in the near future. With growing Internet usage, Java's suitability in this area can help the language become more popular. And there doesn't seem to be any language eating into Java's share (except C#).

So, the winner is (drum rolls please...): Java! I think it is a good idea to learn Java if you're a student or if you're searching for a better job. Expertise in a widely used language translates to more choices when it

comes to jobs. Even if yours is not a software job, it makes sense to learn Java. That is because software is becoming more pervasive and from industry automation to medical devices, software (and Java) is everywhere—so, learning Java can only help you.

What the future holds...

Many well-known researchers and practitioners are working on new languages or proposed ideas for new languages. For example, John McCarthy (of Lisp fame) proposed a language named Elephant [www-formal.stanford.edu/jmc/elephant/elephant.html] that is based on speech and is more like natural language. In the past, COBOL tried to have English-like syntax, and I still have to meet a programmer who likes its syntax.

C++ extended C, and C was derived from B language. Many languages were touted as the *next great language*, such as the D language. But D [www.digitalmars.com/d/] by Walter Bright—a practitioner and creator of 'Digital Mars' C and C++ compilers—is only drawing limited attention. D is mostly based on C++, but also has some features from Java, Eiffel and C#. D will be easy to learn for C++ programmers since its syntax is very similar. The language has some cool features like compile-time function execution (meta-programming).

Programming in functional languages has many advantages and for many applications, functional programs are better than OO or procedural programs. However, functional programming is mostly used in academic and research circles, and is not very widely used by 'common programmers'. There are many attempts to bring functional languages to mainstream use. One such attempt is Scala [www.scala-lang.org/], which integrates functional and object-oriented features. It is very close to Java, and is also interoperable with Java.

Go [<http://golang.org/>] is a programming language announced by Google just a few months back (November 09). Since Ken Thompson (of UNIX fame) is one of its designers, and it has the backing of Google, the announcement of Go got much attention in the Internet. It is a systems programming language like C and has C-like syntax, and programs execute fast like C programs. Go is safe to use—it has type safety, garbage collection, etc. It is also a concurrent language. Moreover, it is an open source language, and has some cool features (like true closures). With this background, Go will certainly be a language to watch out for. 

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